

STORM POWER

Minerals that settle on the seabed are not far from the surface, and mix easily with the surface waters. This happens mainly during storms that stir up the water, scouring mud off the seabed so it billows up into the sunlit water above. Here, it provides phytoplankton with the nutrients it needs to grow, multiply, and feed other marine life.



▲ WHALE SHARK

Filtering the water through its sievelike gills, this whale shark feeds on the swarming microscopic life that makes shallow seas look cloudy.

TEEMING LIFE

Phytoplankton multiply fast in shallow coastal seas, where there is sunlit water with plenty of nutrients. The phytoplankton can be so dense that it makes the water look green and cloudy. It looks like pollution, but it is a sign that the water is teeming with microscopic life.

RICH FISHERIES

The flourishing life in coastal seas supports big schools of fish such as herrings, sardines, and anchovies.

Since these fish are important sources of human food, it means that many of the world's most valuable fisheries are found in shallow coastal waters. Until recently, there was no point in fishing the deep ocean, but overfishing in shallower seas has made many coastal fish scarce.

